Department of History
National University of Singapore

HY5305: Approaches to World History

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AY 2026-27
Semester 1
Class hours: Thurs 6-9 pm
Classroom: LT14

Research Project and related assessment details

Assessment

40%	Poster & project explanation (2300-2500 words), due by **Sun, 15 Nov**
20%	Poster/ project presentation (Weeks 8-10)
20%	Abstract submission (300-500 words), due by **Wed, 16 Sept**
20%	Class participation/ activities

Poster & Project Explanation (40%)

Output: 2,300–2,500 words + exhibition poster

Due Sunday, 15 November

What are you being asked to do?

For this research project, you will design a proposal for a museum exhibition centred on global/world history. You will identify a thematic concern of your choice and develop that theme through the interpretation and display of three to four objects. The objects should come from different regions, periods, and cultural contexts, and may take a variety of forms, including material objects, texts, photographs, artworks, digital media, or other forms of historical evidence.

The purpose of the project is not simply to research three or four interesting objects. Rather, you should use the objects to construct a compelling historical narrative or argument. Your exhibition should demonstrate how objects can be used to think historically about connections, comparisons, movement, encounters, scale, space, time, or other questions relevant to global history. Consider what becomes visible when your objects are brought together within a shared curatorial framework.

Your submission consists of two connected components:

1. An exhibition poster that visually presents your proposed exhibition and its principal objects (3-4 objects).
2. A 2,300–2,500-word project explanation that explains and develops the historical and curatorial thinking behind the exhibition.

The poster and written explanation should work together, but they do not need to duplicate one another. The poster should give a visitor a clear and engaging sense of the exhibition, while the written component should provide the research, interpretation and justification that underpin your curatorial decisions.

Structure of the project explanation
Your project explanation should be organised under the following broad headings. You may adapt these headings or organise the material differently if this better serves your exhibition, but you should address at least some of the questions and issues outlined below.

a) Project objectives, overarching theme, key message(s)
Think of this section as your exhibition pitch. Explain the central idea of your exhibition and what you want visitors to understand, question or take away from it.

You might consider:
- What is the exhibition about? Explain your overarching theme and its significance
- What is the central historical question, argument or narrative?
- Why is this an important story to tell?
- Why have you chosen this particular thematic approach?
- What does the exhibition reveal about global/world history?
- What does "global" mean in this exhibition?
- Why are these objects particularly effective for telling this story?

You do not need to answer every question above. Focus on the aspects that are most important to your exhibition. By the end of this section, a reader should understand what your exhibition is trying to do and why it matters.

b) Object interpretation
This should form the bulk of your project explanation. Develop your exhibition's thematic argument in detail and explain how your chosen objects work together to communicate it.

You should:
- explain how your exhibition is organised, if it is divided into sections;
- discuss the relationship between your objects;
- provide a substantive commentary on each of your three to four principal objects;
- explain how each object contributes to your larger historical argument;
- consider questions of space, time, scale, connection and/or comparison where relevant;
- draw on appropriate historical and scholarly research to contextualise and interpret your objects.

Remember that global history does not simply mean choosing objects from different parts of the world and putting them together without purposeful intent. You should think carefully about the theme, relationship between the objects and about what your particular mode of comparison, connection or juxtaposition allows the exhibition to show. Your objects should therefore have a curatorial reason for being together. They might reveal connections across regions; illuminate a shared phenomenon through comparison; trace the movement of people, ideas, materials, technologies or practices; expose differences between societies; or allow visitors to see a familiar historical question at a different scale. The central question to keep asking is: What does bringing these objects together allow visitors to see, understand or question that they might not see from the objects individually?

Objects are not limited to tangible museum artefacts. They may include texts, photographs, artworks, videos, social media posts, blog posts, memes, websites, posters, interactive maps, self-guided tour instructions, music, soundscapes, animations, comic strips or other forms of

material or digital evidence. Where relevant, identify the creator, source, collection or institution associated with the object.

Through your research, select and distil the historical, literary, cultural, anthropological or other relevant information needed to explain the significance of each object in relation to your chosen theme and to global history. You are not expected to provide a comprehensive history of each object. Prioritise information that advances the argument of your exhibition.

Designing the exhibition poster

The poster is the visual face of your exhibition proposal. It should communicate the exhibition's central idea and give viewers a clear sense of the objects through which you will tell your story. There is no single correct poster format: you are encouraged to make creative decisions about layout, typography, imagery, colour, sequencing and the amount of text according to the needs of your exhibition.

At a minimum, the poster should make clear:

- the title of your exhibition that shows its central theme, question or argument;
- the three to four principal objects through which you explore that theme;

You may organise the poster chronologically, geographically, thematically, comparatively, spatially, or in another way that suits your argument. You might use a short introductory text, object labels, quotations, maps, diagrams, timelines, connecting lines, visual juxtapositions or other devices. It should be visually engaging, legible and selective, while giving viewers enough information to understand the exhibition's central idea.

The three to four objects should be prominent, but they do not need to occupy identical amounts of space. You might foreground one object as a central point of departure, arrange the objects as a sequence, place them in dialogue with one another, or use them to anchor different sections of the exhibition. The design is yours to determine, provided that the visual organisation helps communicate your historical and curatorial argument.

Formatting

There is no standard prescribed formatting for the written components of this research project. You are free to present your ideas as you see fit both in the poster and the project explanation section. Please use footnotes and not endnotes or in-text citations (where relevant). Be consistent with the citation and bibliography style (whatever format you choose to use). If you are new to this, you can begin by consulting the *Chicago Manual of Style* https://www.chicagomanualofstyle.org/home.html. Please note that the bibliography is not part of the word count.

Research Project marking band descriptors

A range = Superior, exceptional, outstanding project ideas with evidence of critical, informed, and creative inquiry that displays their understanding of essential concepts. This means the student demonstrates depth of insight beyond what is normally expected. Carefully nuanced reasoning and writing, free from material, structural and grammatical error are presupposed in this grade.

B range = Good, ready command of full range of concepts/ideas and shows some critical, informed, and creative inquiry that deepens their understanding of essential concepts. This means the student has produced an assignment that is free from material, structural and grammatical errors.

C range = Acceptable, satisfactory ability to describe overall picture and essential concepts. This means the student has completed the assignment in a manner involving no significant errors. Material may not be free from structural and grammatical errors. Nuanced reasoning is not demonstrated.

D range = Below normal expectation. Reasoning is neither carefully nuanced nor coherently presented; writing is insufficient in depth of insight; presentation is not free from material error in structure, spelling and grammar. This means that the student failed to respond adequately to the assignment and its intentions.

F = Unsatisfactory. The student failed to respond to the assignment: 1) failed to turn in the assignment; 2) did not respond to the assignment as given; 3) submitted work so thoroughly flawed as to indicate that the student did not make a serious effort, 4) plagiarism or cheating involved.

Submission

Please upload your work in Word or PDF format to the appropriate folder in Canvas (Assignments tab). If you have videos/ interactive media, please add them as a link inside the document. Do not embed the video in the Word or PDF file.

A reminder about plagiarism

The University takes a strict view of cheating in any form, deceptive fabrication, plagiarism and violation of intellectual property and copyright laws. Any student who is found to have engaged in such misconduct will be subject to disciplinary action by the University. Please refer to the NUS Code of Conduct for further details.

Scaffolding assessments related to the research project

To help you scaffold the project and receive feedback, the course features two related assessment elements, namely the abstract submission (300-500 words; 20%) where you pitch your exhibition idea and short oral presentations centred on your poster and project idea in class (20%).

Abstract submission (300-500 words), due by Wed, 16 Sept (20%)

You will write an abstract outlining your project. You will need to identify and briefly explain your chosen thematic idea under which your objects will be curated. At this stage, you do not need to have identified all your objects, but you should have a sense of how the final product looks like and what message your exhibition intends to communicate.

Poster-Project Presentations, Weeks 8-10 (20%)

You will provide an 8-minute pitch on your project to your tutor and peers. Your pitch should clearly illustrate what your exhibition is about, what narrative you are telling and through what objects. You should at this point present a draft version of your exhibition poster and guide the audience through your project ideas and the specific objects you have chosen. Besides sticking to the time limit (you will be timed), please ensure that your presentation (including the slides) is clear and engaging.

Schedule

Due		Task	Submission	Weightage
Week 6	Wed 16 Sept	Abstract submission	Canvas/ Teams	20%

Weeks 8-10	Thurs 8, 15, 22 Oct	Presentations	Live in class	20%
Week 13	Sun 15 Nov	Poster and project explanation	Canvas (Turnitin)	40%